disruptive to posit its opposite—going directly to the people, enduring hard physical labour of walking more than 25 kilometres a day, living in makeshift camps and waking up at 4 a.m. to start walking by 6 a.m. This feeling of doing something ‘different’ was very evident in the yatris we met.

After meeting the yatris and being cordially invited to share their lunch, along with some sixty to seventy social and political activists and intellectuals from Telangana, we joined a discussion meeting with Rahul Gandhi in the small adjoining tent. Rahul Gandhi made a small opening statement about the objectives of the Yatra and then there was a freewheeling question-and-answer session for about an hour. What was striking was Rahul Gandhi’s willingness to field all kinds of questions and try to answer them sincerely. And soon enough, it was time for the afternoon lap of the Yatra. We met many local activists who had joined the Yatra for short periods, ranging from half a day to the entire duration of the march through Telangana. So in addition to the all-India yatris, there were also state-level yatris who increased its numbers. It is also necessary to point out the energizing impact it had on the Congress party’s cadre and local-level leaders in Telangana, who had been demoralized for quite some time by the near monopoly of power of the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (now Bharat Rashtra Samithi). It did have an impact on the region, as the Telangana elections in December 2023 showed.

The second occasion to be part of the Yatra was on 11 January 2023 in Punjab. We were surprised and delighted to receive an invitation from Rahul Gandhi to join him on the Yatra, and in discussion with his team a date and place was fixed. Driving down from Delhi and staying overnight in Chandigarh, we reached Mandi Gobindgarh, a small town on the Delhi–Srinagar highway, on a bitterly cold day around noon. We went to the tent housing the yatris, many of whom were wrapped in quilts to shelter themselves from the cold, and spent time discussing their experiences on the Yatra. As before, we found enthusiasm, resolve and a sense of purpose. We were to join the Yatra and walk with Rahul Gandhi in the afternoon lap. We were asked to go ahead and wait a few kilometres down the road, as there was too much of a crowd at the beginning of the Yatra. As the Yatra